

Counselor Ethical Boundaries and Practices

Kolby Ray

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CNL-505, Grand Canyon University

Dr. Diedre Wade

Section 1

Boundary Issues and Dual Relationships

When determining whether a dual relationship is appropriate within a counseling relationship, the counselor should consider the pros and cons of the relationship. The decision should also be made with caution and should not be taken lightly. At the beginning of the counseling relationship, the counselor and the client are to set clear boundaries of what is appropriate and what is not. In some cases, these boundaries become a bit of a gray area and boundaries may be crossed. It's important to remember that there is a significant difference between crossing boundaries and violating boundaries. The concepts of crossing and violating boundaries are different in nature and involve different interactions between counselor and client. Crossing boundaries usually involves the counselor briefly operating outside their usual professional limits temporarily. In addition, a counselor should not do so unless they feel that it will benefit their client. On the contrary, violating boundaries involves a counselor engages in a behavior that is unprofessional and inappropriate that inherently causes harm to their client and relationship. Both crossing boundaries and violating boundaries involve bending/breaking the rules, however the severity of the situation as well as the severity of the consequences are very different. According to the ACA Code of Ethics, a counselor that is contemplating engaging in a dual relationship with a client should consider the risks and rewards and should take the necessary precautions to not cause harm to the client (ACA, 2014). Corey claims that before engaging in a dual relationship, the counselor should also ask themselves these questions: Will this benefit the counseling relationship? Is the relationship necessary, or can I avoid it? Can this relationship cause harm to my client? Can I remain objective? (Corey et al., 2023). Thoroughly consider your answers to these questions before making the decision.

There are many real-life examples of situations in which a counselor must determine whether a behavior is appropriate. One example that is common in counseling is when there is physical attraction between the counselor and their client. Sexual relations of any kind albeit with a client or client's family member is strictly prohibited (ACA, 2014). A sexual relationship with a former client or family member of the client is allowed after a 5-year period since the last meeting took place (ACA, 2014). Another example of this is when a client asks to borrow money from their counselor. What may seem harmless at first can quickly turn into something bad. Although the topic of money lending is not covered in the ACA Code of Ethics, it is still a situation that should be carefully thought out. When money is not paid back, it will more than likely damage the counseling relationship. Another example may involve a counselor receiving an invitation to a client's wedding or another type of celebration. The ACA warns counselors that engaging in that type of dual relationship could potentially cause harm to the relationship and that the counselor should consider the risks of the situation (ACA, 2014). One final example involves a counselor receiving a gift from their client. Accepting a gift from a client isn't necessarily a bad thing, but the counselor should, as in all similar cases, consider the potential risks. In addition to a risk analysis, the counselor should evaluate their relationship with this client, the monetary value of the gift, and the client's motivation for giving the gift (ACA, 2014). In some cultures, giving small gifts is a sign of friendship and gratitude (ACA, 2014).

Section 2

Professional Collaboration in Counseling

While working in a public behavioral health care system, a counselor will be working alongside other behavioral health care professionals such as inpatient coordinators, case managers, psychologists, psychiatrists, and dietitians. Learning to work well together is crucial in

the success and quality of care for the patients/clients. I think the first step a counselor should take is to learn each of his or her colleagues' jobs and responsibilities. Doing so will help prevent one professional stepping on the other's toes. Getting on the same page with your colleagues will ensure that the patient/client receives the best quality care possible. In section D of the ACA Code of Ethics, it states that counselors should acknowledge that their colleagues have different areas of expertise and that they should respect them and their practice (ACA, 2014). The ACA also urges counselors to build relationships with their colleagues from different areas of behavioral health expertise to better serve the client (ACA, 2014).

When I become a licensed counselor, I would like to work in a treatment center of some kind. As the counselor there, I would be working with inpatient coordinators, psychiatrists, and case managers. One of the main people I would work with would be the case managers for each resident at the treatment center. The case manager should be up to date on what the patient's needs are and what areas I should focus on while meeting with them in a therapeutic setting. Working with a psychiatrist is important as well because of the limits of my practice. As a counselor, I cannot prescribe medication or diagnose a mental illness, that is where the psychiatrist would come in. My job as the counselor is mainly talk therapy, whereas the psychiatrist will dive deeper into the root of the issue and what types of medication would work best for the client. To ensure that the team is working effectively together, responsibilities should be designated to professionals that are compatible with their skills and experiences (ACA, 2014).

Section 3

Relationships with Supervisors and Colleagues

Counselor supervisors, trainers, and educators strive to build effective and respectful professional relationships while creating appropriate boundaries with their supervisees and

students, in both face-to-face and digital interactions (ACA, 2014). They are grounded in theoretical and pedagogical principles that guide their work and are familiar with various supervision models. Their goal is to conduct fair, accurate, and honest evaluations of counselors, students, and supervisees (ACA, 2014). Just like in most professional relationships, with clients or colleagues, ethical issues can arise from time to time. These ethical issues can range from competence to unethical training processes, to romantic or sexual feelings and desires (Favero et al., 2023). Just as they are in professional and client relationships, they are prohibited in supervisor and supervisee relationships. Supervisors have a major responsibility in helping the supervisee receive the training that they need to fulfill their responsibilities as a professional counselor (Corey et al., 2024). Both supervisors and their supervisees have a list of responsibilities in their supervision relationship. In addition, informed consent is also an important concept and is advised to be given orally and written (Corey et al., 2024).

One unethical behavior that counselors may observe their colleague engage in is the breach of confidentiality. This happens when a counselor or other behavioral health professional discloses information about a client that was supposed to remain confidential. Confidentiality is one of the main focuses of the ACA Code of Ethics because of the legal and ethical liabilities. To address this unethical behavior, a counselor might turn to the ACA Practitioner's Guide to Ethical Decision Making. This model is founded on 5 core principles, autonomy, justice, beneficence, non-maleficence, and fidelity (Davis & Forrester-Miller). This model consists of 7 steps that one can take before making a decision about an ethical issue. The 7 steps are first to identify the problem, apply the ACA Code of Ethics, determine the nature and dimensions of the dilemma, generate potential courses of action, consider the potential consequences of all options,

and determine a course of action, evaluate the selected course of action, and implement the course of action (Davis & Forester-Miller).

Section 4

Development of Your Thinking about Ethics

Aside from what I learned about ethics, something that surprised me that I now have better insight into was the importance of self-care to mitigate the effects of burnout. Due to the high demands of counselors, we are at risk of experiencing burnout (Thompson et al., 2012). During this course, I have learned so much about ethics and their importance in professional counseling. I knew there were ground rules for counseling, but I did not know the extent to which the ACA put in detail each section put in the Code of Ethics. It is honestly comforting to know that there are clear and detailed guidelines for almost every ethical situation that I may face as a counselor. One of the biggest questions I had about this career was about ethics and what we should and shouldn't do in certain situations. I also love that multiple facets of the Code of Ethics are left up to how the counselor feels the situation will be most effectively handled. I like this because it shows that the ACA trusts us as professionals to do what we believe is best. Along with that, the ACA urges us on multiple occasions to assess the potential risks of a given situation and leave it up to the counselor to decide if the situation will be beneficial for our client or not. I now feel confident that when I am faced with these ethical situations, I have the tools that I need to be able to make the right decision. This course was filled with information and knowledge that is foundational to my future career as a counselor and I am grateful for the opportunity to be a part of it.

References

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